

money is most often a character flaw and not a result of a terrible tragedy. Debt is where money becomes your enemy. Money is your most trusted friend, but it always has a sinister element to it, waiting to turn on you. It only takes a momentary lapse—a vacation you couldn't really afford, a medical disaster that strikes when you have no Catastrophe Cash Fund to fall back on—for your money to turn.

The Relationship Due Diligence checklist is the perfect way to expose a spendaholic. Pay special attention to your prospective partner's credit score. Chances are their credit rating has taken a hit—probably many hits—from years of reckless spending. If your partner has an abysmal score, move on. You can't afford to get involved with someone whose spending is out of control.

3. The Loafer

In the loafer's mind, he's living the good life. He may be an over-aged trustafarian who has always been able to count on Mommy and Daddy to pay the bills, or perhaps he simply has a low standard of living and lacks ambition to aim for more. On the Relationship Due Diligence checklist, there's a high probability he put down his occupation as "artist" or "freelance consultant." I'm not knocking true artists and freelancers, those who actually are financially independent thanks to their talents, but the loafer often masquerades as such without actually pulling it off. He is chronically unemployed, though he claims to be "between jobs." More likely is that he's been perpetually fired because he lacks the motivation to show up and make an effort.

The loafer has never really had to worry about money, so he doesn't understand the importance of working for it. He also doesn't care much about saving it, because past experience has affirmed his life philosophy: when he needs it, it will come. And guess what: those declarations of love he keeps whispering to you? Those are because you're the most beautiful and curvaceous dollar sign he's ever seen.